

CDN Incident Alert: 0115. TLP: CLEAR**Date****Title** MD Overloading the Moldovan Elections - The Strategic Use of Faith in Operation Matushka - co-opting Western ultra-conservative media 16/04/2026**Summary**

- A Russian Orthodox Church-facilitated delegation of Western ultra-conservative media figures visited Moldova days before its September 2025 parliamentary elections. The delegation produced religious persecution narratives that were systematically weaponised by the Operation Matushka FIMI infrastructure to suppress pro-EU voter turnout and mobilise Orthodox voters for anti-EU blocs. The operation exploited the delegates' credibility and pre-existing conservative networks to lend authenticity to Kremlin-aligned electoral interference, regardless of whether the participants acted with awareness or intent.
- Russia is framed as a defender of Christian civilisation against a secular, persecutory West, with Moldova's EU alignment portrayed as an existential threat to Orthodox identity.
- The operation achieved wide distribution through print, broadcast, and social media channels in the final campaign days, though the pro-European PAS ultimately secured a parliamentary majority.
- The operation facilitates state propaganda and cultivates support for pro-Russian political allies by co-opting Western religious influencers to lend credibility to Kremlin-aligned narratives, amplified through the clandestine mass production and distribution of the Salt and Light newspaper.
- Delegation members should disclose funding sources, and competent authorities should pursue a financial investigation into sanctioned Russian-linked networks potentially behind the trip's facilitation.

Incident

In September 2025, a delegation of six Western media figures and religious commentators led by Charles Bausman visited Moldova and Moscow, in a trip facilitated by the Russian Orthodox Church. The trip happened weeks before Moldova's 28 September parliamentary elections, producing content alleging Orthodox Christian persecution under Moldova's pro-European government. Several delegation members maintain documented ties to MAGA-aligned networks, including attendance at Mar-a-Lago events associated with Donald Trump, and the accreditation of delegation member John-Henry Westen's outlet LifeSiteNews to the Pentagon press corps in October 2025. The content was subsequently amplified through the Salt and Light newspaper and associated Telegram, Facebook, and TikTok channels, which were linked to Operation Matushka (a Russian FIMI campaign connected to Doppelganger). The content also reached Moldovan voters through MD24 television and distributed printed newspapers with the explicit goal of mobilising Orthodox voters against pro-EU candidates.

Narrative

Meta-narrative 1: Russia is a moral and spiritual sanctuary for Christians.

Sub-Narrative 1-1: The West and the EU are too pro-LGBT and liberal, which makes it incompatible with the Orthodox faith.

Sub-Narrative 1-2: Russia is the only country protecting traditional values in Europe.

Meta-narrative 2: Moldovan pro-European governance represents an existential threat to Orthodox faith and traditional values.

Sub-Narrative 2-1: Moldova's pro-EU government is actively persecuting Orthodox believers, and only a vote for anti-EU political blocs can protect the Church.

Impact and Outcome

Reach: The Salt and Light network distributed over 200,000 newspapers across Chişinău households, supplemented by social media channels on Telegram, Facebook, and TikTok, and broadcast amplification via MD24 television reaching Moldovan voters in the final days of the campaign.

Outcome: Despite the interference operation, the pro-European PAS won 50.20% of the vote and secured a single-party majority of 55 out of 101 seats, though the pro-Russian Patriotic Electoral Bloc came second with 24.19%, and Moldovan police separately documented tens of millions of dollars in Russian vote-buying affecting approximately 10% of the active electorate.

Key Objectives and Behaviours

Objective 1: [Technique T0002: Facilitate State Propaganda](#) - The narratives shared by both the delegation members and *Salt and Light* newspaper (and associated sources) have been closely aligned with Russian state propaganda regarding its view on religion and the conservative movement.

Objective 2: [Technique T0136.006: Cultivate Support for Ally](#) - The operation attempted to cultivate support for the pro-Russian Patriotic Electoral Bloc via the mobilisation of Orthodox voters.

[Technique T0100.003: Co-Opt Influencers](#) - The delegation invited known influencers in the UK, US, and Canadian religious communities to lend credibility and legitimacy in propagating anti-West, conservative narratives surrounding the Moldovan 2025 elections.

[Technique T0111.002: Newspaper](#) - The operation utilised a clandestine newspaper production, which wrote, printed, and en masse distributed the *Salt and Light* newspaper.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions Taken: Chişinău police raided an unauthorised printing facility on 23 September 2025 and confiscated over 200,000 copies of the *Salt and Light* and associated newspapers containing unauthorised electoral content.

Recommendations: Delegation members should be transparent about who funded their travel, accommodation, and meetings, and whether they were aware of any connections to sanctioned entities or Russian state interests.

Report	Threat Actor	Authors	Platforms	FIMI assessment
Link	Russia	Maria Voltsichina, Alliance4Europe; Dr. Lumi Sarvela, Alliance4Europe.	TikTok, Telegram, Facebook	High Certainty

Evidence

Full Report: <https://alliance4europe.eu/report/overloading-the-moldovan-elections>